

Lesson 3: Basic Sentence Structure for ICT Beginners

Course: English for ICT - L1 Computer Science Students

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Lesson Objective

To help ICT students understand the fundamental structure of English sentences - including subject-verb agreement, sentence order, articles, and sentence types - in order to write and speak accurately in professional and technical contexts.

Understanding Sentence Structure in English

A sentence is a group of words that expresses a complete thought. Every correct English sentence has at least two essential parts:

- A subject (who or what the sentence is about)
- A verb (what the subject does or is)

In ICT, clear sentence structure is vital for writing technical descriptions, project documentation, emails, and reports.

For example:

"The technician installs the new software."

Here, The technician is the subject, installs is the verb, and the new software is the object - together forming a clear, complete sentence.

Subject-Verb Agreement

Definition

Subject-verb agreement means the verb form must match the subject in number and person.

- Singular subjects take singular verbs (usually ending in -s).
- Plural subjects take plural verbs (no -s in the base form).

ICT Context Examples

Subject	Verb	Complete Sentence
The computer	works	The computer works efficiently.

Subject	Verb	Complete Sentence
Computers	work	Computers work efficiently.
The technician	troubleshoots	The technician troubleshoots system errors.
Developers	write	Developers write application code.
An engineer	designs	An engineer designs new network systems.

Tip: In ICT documentation, incorrect subject-verb agreement (e.g., "The software run correctly") can make technical writing sound unprofessional or unclear.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Don't forget the -s for singular third-person subjects:
Incorrect: The server run well. Correct: The server runs well.
- Be careful with collective nouns:
Correct: The IT team is working on the issue. (team = one group)

Subject-Verb-Object (SVO) Structure

Definition

English follows a Subject + Verb + Object order in most sentences.
The subject performs the verb's action on the object.

ICT Examples

Sentence	Subject	Verb	Object
Programmers write code.	Programmers	write	code
Users access information online.	Users	access	information
The technician installs hardware.	The technician	installs	hardware
Engineers develop new software.	Engineers	develop	software
Students test applications.	Students	test	applications

This structure helps you form clear and direct technical sentences such as:

"The database stores customer information."

"The operating system manages all processes."

Why It Matters in ICT Writing

SVO ensures clarity in your writing. For example, in reports:

"The program detects errors and displays messages."

This direct structure improves readability and professionalism.

Use of Articles in ICT Contexts

Definition

Articles are small but powerful words that define or identify nouns.

- A / An → Indefinite articles (used when mentioning something for the first time or something general).
- The → Definite article (used for something specific or already known).

Examples in ICT

Article	Example Sentence	Explanation
A	A programmer writes code.	Any programmer, not specific.
An	An application requires regular updates.	"An" before vowel sound.
The	The software development process involves several stages.	Refers to a specific, known process.

Tip:

In ICT, article choice often affects precision:

- "A network" → any network.
- "The network" → a specific one, such as the company's internal network.

Sentence Types in Technical English

English sentences can be grouped into four types, each with a unique purpose.

Understanding them helps ICT students express instructions, ask for clarification, and report technical details effectively.

Type	Function	Example (ICT Context)
Declarative	States a fact or opinion	"Computers process data quickly."
Interrogative	Asks a question	"Do you have experience with network security?"
Imperative	Gives a command or instruction	"Install the latest software update."
Exclamatory	Expresses strong emotion or surprise	"What an innovative solution!"

Note: Declarative sentences are the most common in technical writing, while imperative forms are often used in manuals or installation guides.

Common ICT Writing Errors

Even advanced students make small but important structural mistakes. Here are frequent ones and how to fix them:

Incorrect	Correct	Explanation
The engineer test the system.	The engineer tests the system.	Subject-verb agreement.
Installs the program.	The technician installs the program.	Missing subject.
A application needs update.	An application needs an update.	Wrong article usage.
You are finish the setup?	Are you finishing the setup?	Wrong question structure.
The system not work.	The system does not work.	Missing auxiliary verb.

Encourage students to proofread for these errors when writing ICT reports or project summaries.

Activities (Revised and Enhanced)

Activity 1 - Fix the Sentence (10 min)

Identify and correct the mistakes in subject-verb agreement or article usage:

1. The software run smoothly.
2. Users accesses the database daily.
3. The technician install a printer.
4. A engineer tests the system.
5. The IT team resolve the issue quickly.

Activity 2 - Write It Right (10 min)

Rewrite the following phrases as complete SVO sentences suitable for an ICT report:

1. (user / download / update)
2. (programmer / design / interface)
3. (engineer / test / connection)
4. (developer / fix / bug)
5. (administrator / manage / server)

Activity 3 - Match and Build (10 min)

Match the sentence type with the correct example and then create one of your own.

Type	Example
Declarative	The application saves data automatically.
Interrogative	Do you use this programming language?
Imperative	Restart your computer now.
Exclamatory	What a powerful processor!

Now write one original example of each type related to ICT.

Activity 4 - ICT Sentence Construction Challenge (15 min)

Form five complete sentences describing what happens in a computer lab or IT department, using different sentence structures (declarative, interrogative, imperative, exclamatory).

Example:

"The technician updates all computers."

"Do you back up your data regularly?"

"Check the internet connection first!"

"What an efficient new router!"

Summary

In this lesson, we learned that:

- Every sentence must have a subject and verb that agree in number and person.
- The SVO structure ensures clarity and professionalism in technical writing.
- Articles ("a," "an," "the") define whether a noun is general or specific.
- Different sentence types serve different communication purposes.

Mastering these elements helps ICT students write clearer reports, documentation, and technical explanations - a vital skill for both study and work.